

Set Up Your Own CRE Deal Desk.

A plain-English guide — no coding, and you never open or edit a single file. If you can install an app and copy-and-paste into a website, you can do this. We go one small step at a time and tell you exactly what you'll see after each one.

~10 min

start to finish

Double-click

no terminal, no code

Your box

your deals stay home

Your own private commercial-real-estate deal workspace, running on your computer — a CRM, an AI deal agent, an underwriting-model builder, lender matching, and market data, at the model's cost with no software markup, no per-seat fees, and no credits that expire.

Three phases. You can stop after two.

Here's the entire journey before we start, so nothing is a surprise. You'll only ever **double-click** and **use your web browser** — never a command, never a file.

1

Install the engine — Windows only

WINDOWS

On **Windows**, install one free thing: **Python** — the "motor" DealDesk runs on. Two clicks and one checkbox. On a **Mac**, skip this entirely — the motor is already built in.

2

Turn DealDesk on

FREE

Set one password, double-click one file. DealDesk opens in your web browser. You can run deals, build underwriting models, and match lenders **right away — no keys needed.**

3

Add the smarts (your keys)

OPTIONAL

The AI agent, term extraction, drafting, and memos each come to life when you paste your **Anthropic key** in Settings. Connect an inbox to send email. And set a **monthly spend cap** so AI never surprises you.

You never touch code or files. After Phase 2, DealDesk already works — pipelines, deals, a real underwriting Excel, lender matching, and market data, all free. Phase 3 is a menu you turn on inside the app by pasting keys. There's no wrong order and nothing to break.

On a Mac? Start at Phase 2. Macs already have the engine built in, so Phase 1 is Windows-only — skip it. That makes the whole thing about **7 minutes**.

Install the engine

PHASE 1

Windows only — one download, one checkbox, ~3 min. **Mac owners:** skip this page.

DEALDESK

On a Mac? You are already done with Phase 1. macOS ships with Python — the engine DealDesk runs on. Nothing to download. Turn the page to Phase 2.

1

Download Python

In your web browser, go to the address below and click the big yellow **Download Python** button at the top. Don't worry about the version number — whichever one it offers is the right one.

➤ python.org/downloads

What you'll see: a file downloading, with a name like `python-3.13.exe`, in your **Downloads** folder.

2

Run it — and tick the box

Open your **Downloads** folder and double-click the file you just downloaded. An installer window opens with two buttons and a couple of checkboxes at the bottom.

This is the one thing you must not miss. At the bottom of that window, tick **"Add python.exe to PATH"** before you click anything else. Without it, DealDesk can't find the engine and won't start.

Then click **Install Now** and let it run. If Windows asks "Do you want to allow this app to make changes?", click **Yes**.

3

Close it

When it says **Setup was successful**, click **Close**. That's the whole phase — no account, no restart, nothing to leave running.

You're done when: the installer says **Setup was successful**. Python now sits quietly in the background forever; you'll never open it again.

Turn DealDesk on

PHASE 2

DEALDESK

Set a password, double-click, log in. ~2 min — and it already does real work.

1

Get the DealDesk folder onto your computer

If you downloaded a ZIP, double-click it to unzip, and move the `dealdesk` folder somewhere easy — your **Desktop** is perfect. Open the folder; you'll see files like `Start DealDesk.command` (Mac) or `Start DealDesk.bat` (Windows).

2

Set your password

Inside the folder is a file named `.env.example`. Make a copy of it and rename the copy to just `.env` (yes, starting with a dot). Open `.env` in any text editor and change one line:

`DEALDESK_PASSWORD=` type a password of your own after the = sign

That's the only line you must change. This is the password you'll type to log into DealDesk. Save the file and close it.

3

Double-click to start

Double-click **Start DealDesk** — `.command` on Mac, `.bat` on Windows. The first time, it quietly builds itself (about a minute) and then opens your web browser to DealDesk.

On a Mac, the first double-click may say the file is "from an unidentified developer." Right-click it → **Open** → **Open**, just once, and it runs from then on.

➤ it opens to `http://localhost:8799`

4

Log in and look around

Type the password you set and hit **Sign in**. DealDesk comes pre-loaded with **three sample deals, a starter lender book, and market data** so every screen already has something in it.

You now have a working deal desk.

Move deals through pipelines, build a real underwriting Excel, match lenders, and browse market data — all with **zero keys**. Phase 3 adds the AI.

Prefer not to double-click? Advanced users can run it from a terminal instead: `python3 -m venv .venv && source .venv/bin/activate && pip install -r requirements.txt && ./run.sh`. Same result, same port.

Add the smarts — your keys

PHASE 3

The AI agent, term extraction, drafting, and memos wake up when you paste a key. Everything here is optional and pasted in the browser — no files.

DEALDESK

In DealDesk, click **settings** (top-right). Every key below is pasted right there and applied instantly — **no restart, no file editing**.

Anthropic API key

turns on Scout + AI

This one key powers the whole AI side: **Scout** (the agent that answers questions and takes actions from chat), **term extraction** from uploaded documents, **email/memo drafting**, the **offering memorandum**, and **lender pros/cons**. Without it, those features fall back to keyword search, regex, and templates — still usable, just not as sharp.

Where to get it: sign in at console.anthropic.com → **API Keys** → **Create Key**. Copy it (it starts with **sk-ant-**), paste it into the **Anthropic API key** box in Settings, and hit **Save**. Then click **Test Anthropic key** — it should say it reached the model.

Email address + App Password

optional — for the inbox loop

Connect an inbox to **sync recent email into per-deal threads** and **send email from a deal**. Any provider that speaks IMAP/SMTP works (Gmail, Outlook, Fastmail).

Gmail and Outlook need an App Password, not your normal login password. In Gmail: myaccount.google.com → **Security** → **2-Step Verification** (turn on if needed) → **App passwords** → create one for "Mail." Paste that 16-character code as the **Email App Password** in Settings.

After saving, click **Test inbox (IMAP + SMTP)** — it logs in both ways without sending anything, so you know it works before you rely on it.

DealDesk meters what the AI actually costs — the **real token price** of each call against your Anthropic account — and refuses paid AI once you hit your **monthly cap**. A running total sits in the header (AI spend \$X / \$Y) so there are never surprises.

It's yours to adjust, anytime. The cap ships at **\$25/month**. Change it in **Settings → Monthly AI-spend cap (cents)** — e.g. 5000 for \$50 or 10000 for \$100 — and hit Save. It applies immediately, no restart. Set it to whatever you're comfortable spending; when you reach it, DealDesk simply stops making paid calls until next month (or until you raise the cap).

Keys live in your workspace, not the cloud. Everything you paste is stored in the single SQLite file on your own machine and used only to call the service you gave it. Back it up any time from **Backup** in the top nav.

DEALDESK

You're set up

That's it. It's yours now.

No subscription, no per-seat fee, no credits that expire. DealDesk runs on your computer, your data stays home, and you only pay the model's actual cost — capped at whatever you choose.

Run deals

Acquisition & financing boards, tasks, contacts, companies — all free.

Ask Scout

"Run the model on Harbor Pointe" — it does it, from chat.

Stay in control

Real spend metered, capped at your number, backup in one click.

Turn the page (or open the [Feature Guide](#)) for a tour of everything DealDesk can do.